space. It also ensured that he remained in public memory, both in Gujarat and in Delhi. He was a good party spokesperson—clear, direct, aggressive, often provocative. He did not pussyfoot around the party's commitment to Hindutva and never shied away from a joust.

When the Twin Towers were attacked in New York in September 2001, I was looking for a guest for my weekly *Big Fight* show to discuss the new buzzword—Islamic terror. The BJP leaders in the Vajpayee government were for some reason reluctant to appear on the programme. Modi had no such compunctions as he came and spoke out strongly against what he said was one of the biggest threats to the country. 'It has taken an attack like 9/11 for India's pseudo-secular media to finally use a word like Islamic terrorism and wake up to the reality of how some groups are misusing religion to promote terror,' thundered Modi in the programme.

Little did I know then that Modi's position on Islam and terror would subsequently come to define his political identity. I also could not have foreseen that the man who was one of my 'go to' BJP netas for a political debate would never again appear on a television show of this kind. Life for Modi, the country and even for me as a journalist was about to take a dramatic twist.

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Less than four weeks after appearing on *The Big Fight* show on the 9/11 terror attack, Narendra Modi was sworn in as Gujarat's chief minister. It was a remarkable change in fortune for a leader who had found himself on the margins of national politics till then. The change in leadership in Gujarat had been in the offing for some time. Keshubhai Patel's second term as chief minister had been disastrous. The BJP had lost a series of municipal elections and assembly by-elections in the state in the 2000–01 period. On 26 January 2001, as the country was celebrating Republic Day, Kutch and Ahmedabad had been shaken by a devastating earthquake. Instead of seeing this as a wake-up call, Patel's government became even more somnolent. The relief and rehabilitation measures were widely